

And know that when it comes to teaching your kids how to spend, it's never too early to start. You can introduce the ideas of values, parameters, prioritization, and caring for your needs at any age. Allowing kids to join in on the process of valuing resources and recognizing not everything is limitless will only benefit them as they grow into conscientious adults. All that said, we still love our radical middle. It's important to create room in the spending plan wherever possible and within reason to buy the things your kid values, whether you value them or not, as you encourage them on their own path of self-discovery and curiosity-practicing.

The rest of our families encompass numerous relationships beyond our immediate household. When it comes to the adult parents, siblings, grandparents, aunts, uncles, and in-laws, things can get dicey. Not everyone will understand or want to respect the boundaries we set for ourselves. But that doesn't need to keep us from defining and adhering to them.

When you encounter pushback on your boundaries, it's important to truly consider what's livable vs. what's not livable—essentially identifying what matters most.

Here's what I mean. Let's say that your mother-in-law expects extravagant birthday presents. The kind that requires the whole sibling group to contribute a few hundred dollars to the pot. There's also a family expectation that it is *nearly* mandatory to attend one or two family trips a year that all require you to use some precious PTO and pay a significant amount toward lodging and flights. Not to mention all the junk you're obligated to take with you after every visit. From your spouse's third-grade picture to the hideous kitchen towels that her friend got on sale at CVS, it's never something you would gladly take home with you. Like food or money.

In our fake scenario, it could be tempting to allow this whole thing to build up to an explosive point where every detail is brought to light and criticized publicly. We all know that would be devastating. Instead, let's say you decide that right now, the biggest strain is the family vacations. So, you say something like, "We want to give you all a heads-up that we will not be attending the family vacation this year. We love you all very much and we value time with you, but this year we are choosing to prioritize other financial goals. We are hopeful to still have meaningful time together throughout the year." You may then suggest a local long weekend away, or regular bimonthly dinners together, or you choose to host Thanksgiving as a